

Graduate Seminar

An introduction to stochastic calculus with applications to finance and SPDEs

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March 29, 2022

Stochastic Calculus

In Real Analysis we study measurable functions:

$$f : D \rightarrow R,$$

where both D and R are measurable spaces:

$$(D, \sigma(D), \mu_1) \quad \text{and} \quad (R, \sigma(R), \mu_2).$$

In undergraduate Calculus, we focus only on real valued measurable on $\mathbb{R}^d$:

$$f : D \subseteq \mathbb{R}^d \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^d,$$

and the measure space that is implied is the following:

$$(\mathbb{R}^d, \mathcal{B}(\mathbb{R}^d), \lambda),$$

where λ is Lebesgue measure.

Stochastic Calculus

When studying Stochastic Calculus, and in general Probability Theory, we consider measurable functions,

$$X : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^d,$$

and we consider the measure spaces

$$(\Omega, \mathcal{F}, \mathbb{P}) \quad \text{and} \quad (\mathbb{R}^d, \mathcal{B}(\mathbb{R}^d), \lambda),$$

where Ω and $\mathcal{F}$ are referred to as the sample space and set of possible events and

$$\mathbb{P}(\Omega) = 1.$$

Definition (Random Variable)

A measurable function $X : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^d$ is called a $\mathbb{R}^d$ -valued *Random Variable*.

So essentially, Stochastic Calculus and Probability is just Real Analysis on Random Variables.

Stochastic Processes

Definition (Stochastic Process)

A stochastic process is a random variable that is indexed by set, T , which usually represents time:

$$X_t(\omega), \quad t \in T, \omega \in \Omega.$$

One can think a stochastic processes as a two parameter function

$$X_t(\omega) = X(t, \omega) : T \times \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^d.$$

Definition (Sample Path)

The variable ω represents the idea of a single possible outcome. The following function is then referred to as a *sample path*:

$$t \mapsto X_t(\omega).$$

Examples

Example

Suppose we leave a cup out in the rain. We may model this with a stochastic processes as

$$X_t(\omega) = \text{Amount of rain in the cup at time } t.$$

Since $X_t \geq 0$, maybe we could say that

$$X_t \sim \text{Gamma Distribution with } \mu := \mu(t) \text{ and constant variance } \sigma^2$$

If the rain is constant then it makes sense for the variance to be constant. Moreover, as time continuous, there will be more water in the cup on average, so the mean should be a function in time.

Brownian Motion.

Brownian motion is a very widely used stochastic processes. We will construct Brownian motion through a random walk.

Theorem

Consider a random walk $X = \{X_0 = 0, X_{t_1}, \dots, X_{t_n}\}$. Suppose that for $k \in \{1, \dots, n\}$ that

$$\mathbb{P}[X_{t_k} = -h] = \mathbb{P}[X_{t_k} = h] = 1/2.$$

and suppose that the time increments are all constant:

$$t_k - t_{k-1} = d \quad \forall k \in \{1, \dots, n\}.$$

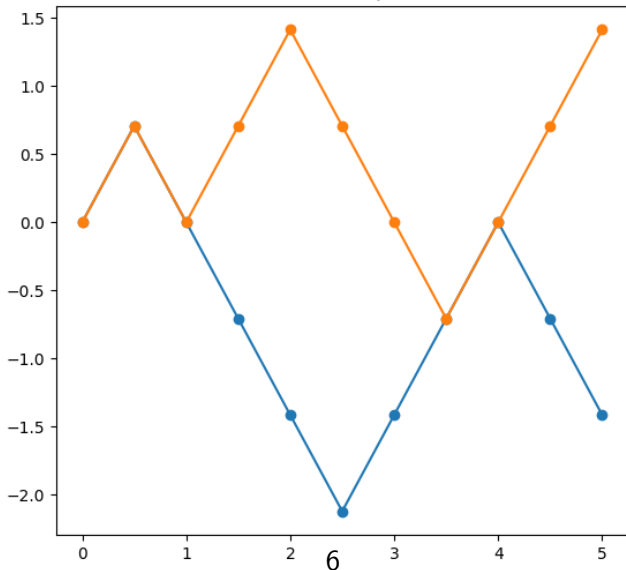
Suppose that $h^2 = d$. Now define

$$B_n(t_k) = \sum_{i=0}^k X_{t_i}.$$

Then B_n converges to a Brownian motion.

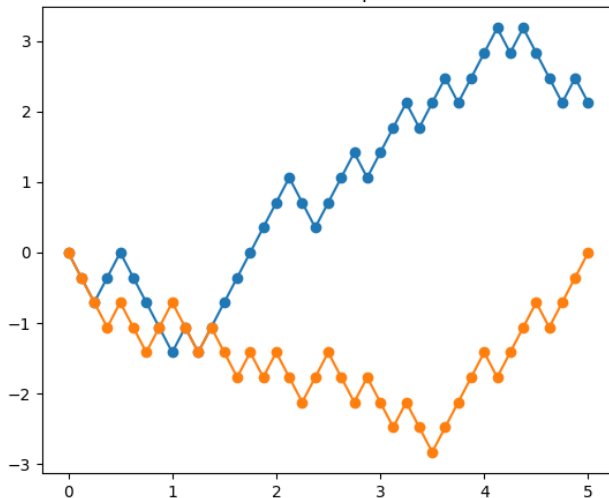
Random Walk Example

2 sample paths of a random walk
jump size = 0.707 and step size = 0.5
number of steps = 10



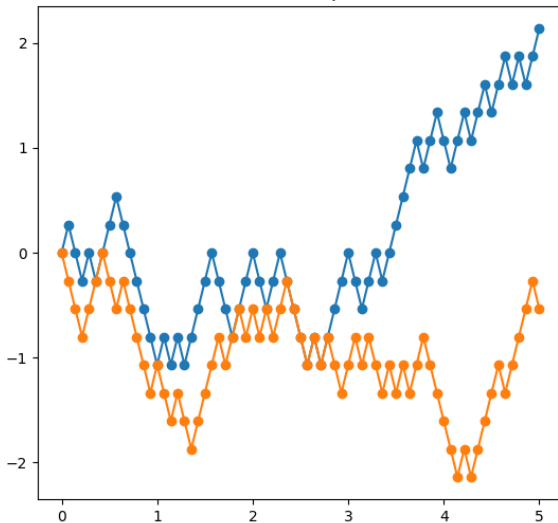
Random Walk Example

2 sample paths of a random walk
jump size = 0.354 and step size = 0.125
number of steps = 40

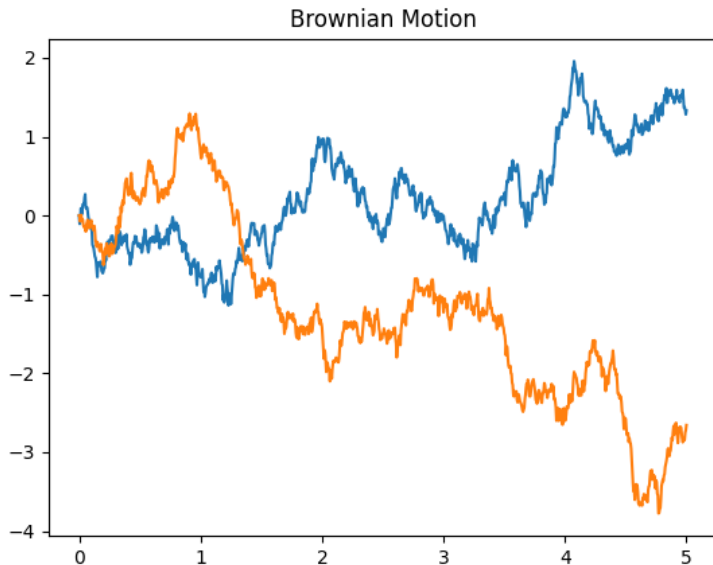


Random Walk Example

2 sample paths of a random walk
jump size = 0.267 and step size = 0.07142857142857142
number of steps = 70



Random Walk Example



Why do we care about Brownian Motion? An application to finance.

Consider a stock that has value S_t at time t . Consider $t = 0$ to be the point of entry into the investment. We can define a return rate as follows:

$$S_t = S_0(1 + R_t), \quad R_t = \text{the return rate over the period } [0, t].$$

We want to make predictions of our return. In a very simple model, we can assume that

$$R_t \sim \text{Normal}(\mu t, \sigma^2), \quad \mu \in \mathbb{R}, \sigma \in (0, \infty).$$

In terms of Stochastic Calculus, we express this as the following stochastic differential equation:

$$dS_t = \mu S_t dt + \sigma S_t dB_t, \quad \text{where } B_t \text{ is a Brownian motion.}$$

Modeling a stock price with geometric brownian motion

The notation

$$dS_t = \mu S_t dt + \sigma S_t dB_t, \quad \text{where } B_t \text{ is a Brownian motion}$$

is only symbolic as dB_t does not exist. The above can be legitimately viewed as the following integral equation:

$$S_t - S_0 = \int_0^t \mu S_k dk + \int_0^t \sigma S_k dB_k.$$

The stochastic processes S_t that solves the above equation is called a Geometric Brownian Motion.

References